

Research Paper: The Aramaic/Syriac Word Elahi — ܐܠܗܝ

A Philological, Grammatical, Textual, and Theological Word Study

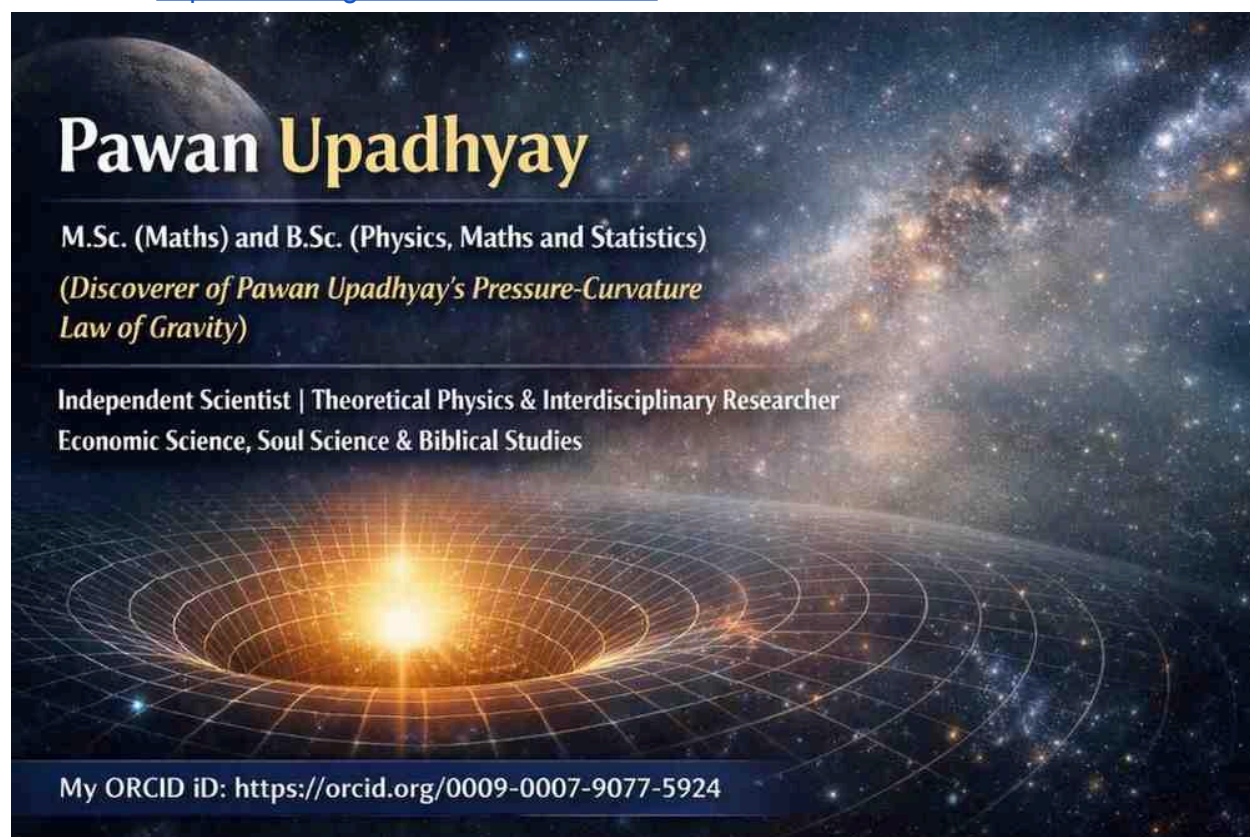
Author: Pawan Upadhyay

Affiliation: Independent Researcher and Independent Scientist

Email: pawanupadhyay28@hotmail.com

2nd Email: pawankanyakubj@gmail.com

ORCID iD: <https://orcid.org/0009-0007-9077-5924>



Abstract

The Aramaic/Syriac form ܐܠܗܝ (*Elāhī/Alāhī*), conventionally translated “**my God**,” occupies an important place in the study of the language of Jesus and the Gospel accounts of the crucifixion. The form consists of the noun ܐܠܗܐ (*Elāhā/Alāhā*), “God, god, deity,” together with a first-person singular possessive element represented by ܐ (-ī). Syriac lexical and grammatical evidence explicitly identifies ܐܠܗܝ as “my God.”

The word is particularly significant in **Mark 15:34**, where the Peshitta records Jesus' cry using the expression ܐܠܗܝ ܐܠܗܝ (**Elāhī Elāhī**) in the explanatory portion of the verse. The same Peshitta tradition also uses ܐܠܗܝ ܐܠܗܝ in its rendering of Psalm 22, demonstrating the close textual relationship between the Gospel saying and Psalm 22.

This study argues that **Elahi is grammatically and lexically “my God” in Syriac/Aramaic**, while cautioning that the Syriac Peshitta should not automatically be treated as a phonetic transcript of the precise Galilean Aramaic spoken by Jesus. The Gospel forms **Eli** and **Eloi**, therefore, must be examined alongside, rather than simply equated with, the later Syriac form **Elahi**.

1. Introduction

Few individual words in the New Testament have generated as much linguistic and theological discussion as the expression traditionally rendered:

“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”

The saying occurs in **Matthew 27:46** and **Mark 15:34** and is explicitly presented in an Aramaic linguistic form before being translated for the Gospel's Greek-speaking audience.

The question addressed in this study is narrower:

What exactly is the word “Elahi,” and what does its form tell us about Aramaic/Syriac grammar, the language of the Gospel tradition, and the relationship between Jesus' saying and Psalm 22?

The answer requires distinguishing at least four linguistic forms:

1. Hebrew ֵלֹהִי (*’ēlōh*) — “my God”
2. Hebrew ֵלֹהָי (*’ēlōhay*) — “my God”
3. Aramaic/Syriac ܐܠܗܝ (*’alāhī / elāhī*) — “my God”
4. Greek transliterations ἑλὶ (*ēlī*) and ἐλωὶ (*elōi*)

These forms are closely related but should not be collapsed into one word.

2. The Syriac Form ܐܠܗܝ

The Syriac spelling is:

ܐܠܗܐ

A commonly used scholarly transliteration is:

’alāhī or **’elāhī**

Depending upon transliteration convention and dialectal pronunciation, one may encounter forms such as:

Elahi / Elāhī / Alāhī

The Syriac lexical form for “God” is:

ܐܠܗܐ — **’Alāhā**

The corresponding first-person possessive form is:

ܐܠܗܐ — **’Alāhī**

A Syriac primer explicitly lists:

ܐܠܗܐ — **God**

ܐܠܗܐ — **my God**

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon likewise identifies **’lh / ’lh’** as an Aramaic noun meaning “god, God,” including its use for the God of Israel.

3. Morphological Analysis

The word can be analyzed approximately as:

ܐܠܗܐ

’alāh + ī

Element	Function	Meaning
ܐܠܗܐ	noun stem	God/deity
ܐ	1st-person singular possessive element	my
ܐܠܗܐ	complete form	my God

Thus:

Elāhī = Elāh + ī = “my God.”

The grammatical evidence is particularly strong because Syriac lexical paradigms explicitly list ܐܠܗܐ under the first-person singular possessive forms of ܐܠܗܐ.

This is important because the meaning does not depend upon theological interpretation. It is fundamentally a **grammatical relationship** between a noun and a first-person possessive form.

4. The Noun ܐܠܗܐ — “God”

The basic Syriac noun is:

ܐܠܗܐ — **ʿAlāhā**

meaning:

- god
- deity
- God

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon identifies the Aramaic form **ʿlh / ʿlh** as a masculine noun meaning “god, God.” Its attestations extend across several Aramaic traditions, including Syriac.

This places Syriac **Elāhā** within a much larger Semitic linguistic family.

Compare:

Language	Form	Meaning
Hebrew	אל (ʿEl)	God / deity
Hebrew	אלוה (ʿEloah)	God
Hebrew	אלהים (ʿElohim)	God
Aramaic	אלה / אלהא	God
Syriac	ܐܠܗܐ (ʿAlāhā)	God
Arabic	إله (ilāh)	deity/god
Arabic	الله (Allāh)	God

The forms are historically related within the Semitic linguistic world, although their precise historical developments should not be reduced to a simplistic one-word-to-another derivation.

5. The Possessive Element “-i”

The final ܐ (-ī) is crucial.

It represents the first-person singular possessive relationship:

“my.”

Therefore:

ܐܠܗܐ — **God**

becomes:

ܐܢܝܐܠܗܐ — **my God**

The same grammatical pattern can be observed in Syriac vocabulary generally. For example, the Syriac glossary gives:

ܐܕܐ — **hand**

and:

ܐܢܝܐܕܐ — **my hand**

alongside:

ܐܠܗܐ — **God**

and:

ܐܢܝܐܠܗܐ — **my God.**

This provides an important control example: the final -ī is not an ornamental addition or a theological interpretation. It is a grammatical possessive marker.

6. “Elahi” and the Hebrew “Eli”

One of the most important distinctions in this study is between:

ܐܠܗܝ — **Elahi**

and:

אֱלִי — **'Eli**

Both can mean:

“my God.”

But they are morphologically different.

Hebrew

אל — **'El**

= God

אֱלִי — **'Eli**

= my God

Psalms 22:1 contains:

אֱלִי אֱלִי

'Eli 'Eli

“My God, my God.”

The Hebrew morphology identifies אֱלִי as “my God,” with the first-person singular element attached to אל.

Syriac/Aramaic

ܐܠܗܐ — **'Alāhā**

= God

ܐܠܗܝ — **'Alāhī**

= my God

Thus:

Hebrew: ʾEli

Aramaic/Syriac: ʾElāhī

They communicate essentially the same semantic relationship but employ different nominal forms.

7. “Elahi” and “Elohai”

Another important comparison is:

אֱלֹהֵי — ʾElohai

Hebrew:

“my God.”

This form derives from **Eloah/Elohim-type morphology**, whereas **Eli** derives directly from **EI**.

Consequently, the following should not be treated as identical words:

EI

Eli

Eloah

Elohai

Elaha

Elahi

Nevertheless, they belong to a closely related Semitic lexical field concerning deity/God.

8. Mark 15:34

Mark's Greek Gospel preserves the cry as:

Ἐλωϊ, Ἐλωϊ, λαμὰ σαβαχθανί

commonly transliterated:

Eloi, Eloi, lama sabachthani

The Greek lexical tradition identifies **ἐλωϊ (elōi)** as an Aramaic-derived expression meaning **“my God.”**

The Syriac Peshitta presents the verse as:

ܐܠܗܝܐ ܐܠܗܝܐ ... ܐܠܗܝܐ ܕܡܝܢ ܕܥܡܝܐ

and explicitly explains the expression with:

ܐܠܗܝܐ ܐܠܗܝܐ

that is:

Elāhī, Elāhī — “my God, my God.”

The Peshitta's grammatical analysis identifies each occurrence of ܐܠܗܝܐ as:

- noun
- masculine singular
- emphatic state
- first-person singular possessive

with the meaning **“God” / “my God.”**

This is one of the strongest pieces of evidence available for the grammatical interpretation of **Elahi**.

9. The Significance of Mark's “Eloi”

The form **Eloi** in Mark and **Eli** in Matthew have generated substantial linguistic discussion.

Matthew 27:46 gives the form traditionally transliterated:

Eli, Eli, lema sabachthani

Mark 15:34 gives:

Eloi, Eloi, lama sabachthani

The difference is significant because Matthew's **Eli** closely resembles the Hebrew of Psalm 22:

אֱלֹהִי אֱלֹהִי — ‘Eli ‘Eli

whereas Mark's **Eloi** is explicitly recognized as an Aramaic form in the Greek tradition.

Thus the Gospel evidence itself preserves more than one linguistic form.

This is why it is methodologically preferable to say:

“Elahi is a valid Syriac/Aramaic form meaning ‘my God’”

rather than:

“Jesus definitely pronounced the word exactly ‘Elahi.’”

The latter assertion requires evidence that the surviving textual tradition cannot independently provide.

10. The Peshitta and “Elahi”

The Peshitta provides particularly valuable evidence because it uses ܐܠܗܝ not only in Mark 15:34 but also in its translation of Psalm 22.

The Peshitta rendering of Psalm 22 begins:

ܐܠܗܝ ܐܠܗܝ ܠܡܗ ܐܠܗܝ ܐܠܗܝ

corresponding to:

“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”

This is highly significant.

The Syriac textual tradition therefore establishes a direct lexical bridge:

Psalm 22 → ܐܠܗܝ ܐܠܗܝ

and:

Mark 15:34 → ܐܠܗܝ ܐܠܗܝ

The connection is not merely theological; it is also **lexical and textual**.

11. Psalm 22 and “My God”

The Hebrew Masoretic text of Psalm 22:1 contains:

אֱלִי אֱלִי לָמָּה עָזַבְתָּנִי

’Eli ’Eli lamah ’azavtani

The first word is:

אֱלִי — ’Eli

and the second is identical:

אֱלִי — ’Eli

The Hebrew grammatical analysis identifies ’Eli as “my God.”

The Gospel quotation therefore places Jesus' final cry directly within the linguistic and literary world of Psalm 22.

12. Aramaic “Elahi” and Hebrew “Eli” in the Gospel Tradition

A useful comparison is:

Feature	Hebrew Psalm 22	Syriac/Aramaic
God	אֱלִי (Eli)	ܐܠܗܐ (Elaha)
My God	אֱלִי (Eli)	ܐܠܗܝ (Elahi)
Double expression	אֱלִי אֱלִי	ܐܠܗܐ ܐܠܗܐ
Meaning	My God, my God	My God, my God

The forms differ, but the semantic content is remarkably stable.

This helps explain why the Gospel writers could preserve an Aramaic saying that simultaneously echoes a Hebrew Psalm.

13. Was Jesus Speaking Syriac?

A critical historical distinction is necessary.

Jesus lived in **first-century Galilee**, where Aramaic was an important spoken language. It is therefore reasonable to describe Jesus as an **Aramaic speaker**.

However, **Classical Syriac** is a particular literary form of Aramaic that became especially associated with the Syriac Christian tradition.

Therefore:

“Jesus spoke Aramaic”

is historically safer than:

“Jesus spoke Classical Syriac.”

The Peshitta is a Syriac translation tradition and is later than the first-century setting of Jesus. Consequently, its precise vocalization should not automatically be projected backward onto Jesus' Galilean speech.

Nevertheless, Syriac is extraordinarily valuable for comparative Aramaic study because it preserves a closely related linguistic system in which ܡܝܬܝܢ **unequivocally means “my God.”**

14. The Historical-Linguistic Caution

A proper word study must distinguish three different questions:

Question 1

What does ܡܝܬܝܢ mean in Syriac?

Answer:

“My God.”

This is grammatically secure.

Question 2

Is ܡܝܬܝܢ an Aramaic form?

Yes. The Aramaic lexical family 'lh is widely attested, including Syriac.

Question 3

Did Jesus himself pronounce the exact Syriac form ܐܠܗܝ?

This cannot be established with the same degree of certainty.

The surviving Gospel texts give **Eli** and **Eloi**, while the Peshitta gives **Elahi** as its Syriac form.

Therefore, linguistic scholarship should not confuse **translation evidence** with **audio-level reconstruction**.

15. Theological Semantics of “My God”

The possessive element is also significant for interpretation.

The phrase is not simply:

“God!”

It is:

“My God!”

The first-person relationship is grammatically encoded.

This means that:

Elahi

contains both:

God

and:

my

The expression is therefore personal rather than merely descriptive.

In the context of Psalm 22, the speaker addresses God directly while simultaneously expressing profound distress.

16. “My God” Does Not Mean “A God”

A common misunderstanding arises when the word is isolated from its possessive morphology.

Elahi does not mean:

“a god of some kind.”

The Syriac grammatical structure identifies a specific relationship:

God + my

Therefore:

Elahi = my God.

The same conclusion is independently demonstrated by Syriac lexical paradigms and the Peshitta text.

17. Relationship to the Divine Name

Another distinction is necessary between:

Elahi

and the Hebrew divine name:

YHWH

They are not the same lexical item.

Elahi means:

“my God.”

It is a title/noun phrase rather than the tetragrammaton itself.

Likewise:

Elohim

and:

YHWH

should not automatically be treated as interchangeable words simply because both can refer to Israel's God.

The linguistic value of **Elahi** lies precisely in the fact that it expresses the speaker's relationship to God:

“my God.”

18. The Broader Semitic Connection

The root represented by 'L-H occurs across Semitic languages.

A simplified comparative table is:

Language	Form	Meaning
Biblical Hebrew	אל (ʿEl)	God
Biblical Hebrew	אלוה (ʿEloah)	God
Aramaic	אלה / אלהא	God
Syriac	ܐܠܗܐ (ʿAlāhā)	God
Syriac	ܐܠܗܝܐ (ʿAlāhī)	My God
Arabic	إله (ilāh)	deity
Arabic	الله (Allāh)	God

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon confirms the Aramaic 'lh lexical field for “god/God.”

The relationship is therefore linguistic and historical rather than merely a superficial similarity of sound.

19. A Note on “Allah”

The similarity between Syriac:

ܐܠܗܐ — **Alāhā**

and Arabic:

الله — **Allāh**

has understandably attracted attention.

Both belong to the Semitic linguistic environment in which forms derived from ancient Semitic vocabulary for deity developed.

However, a responsible academic treatment should avoid presenting:

Elahi → Elaha → Allah

as a simple linear chain of derivation.

Instead, it is better to speak of a **shared Semitic lexical heritage and related historical developments**.

20. Textual Significance

The evidence can be summarized as follows:

Hebrew Psalm

אֱלֹהֵי אֱלֹהֵי

’Eli ’Eli

“My God, my God.”

Greek Mark

Ἐλωϊ, Ἐλωϊ

Eloi, Eloi

“My God, my God.”

Syriac Peshitta Mark

ܐܠܗܝ ܐܠܗܝ

Elahi Elahi

“My God, my God.”

The three forms are linguistically different but semantically converge.

This provides an excellent example of how a saying can move across **Hebrew, Aramaic, Greek, and Syriac** textual environments while preserving its essential meaning.

21. Major Findings

The study produces six principal conclusions.

Finding 1 — Elahi is a genuine Syriac/Aramaic form

ܐܠܗܝ is an attested Syriac form meaning:

“my God.”

Finding 2 — The final -i is grammatically meaningful

The final ܐ (-ī) represents the first-person singular possessive relationship.

Thus:

Elaha → Elahi

may be understood morphologically as:

God → my God.

Finding 3 — Elahi and Eli are not identical forms

Hebrew:

אֱלִי — Eli

and Syriac:

ܐܠܗܝ — **Elahi**

both mean “my God,” but they derive from different nominal forms within closely related Semitic linguistic systems.

Finding 4 — Mark preserves an Aramaic form

Mark's **Eloi** is identified as Aramaic in origin, whereas Matthew's **Eli** closely corresponds to the Hebrew wording of Psalm 22.

Finding 5 — The Peshitta explicitly uses Elahi

The Syriac Peshitta uses:

ܐܠܗܝ ܐܠܗܝ

in Mark 15:34 and Psalm 22, creating a strong Syriac textual correspondence between the Gospel saying and the Psalm.

Finding 6 — Elahi should not automatically be presented as Jesus' exact pronunciation

The Peshitta is Syriac textual evidence rather than a first-century phonographic record. Therefore, **Elahi demonstrates the Syriac/Aramaic linguistic equivalent of “my God,” but does not by itself prove that Jesus' exact Galilean pronunciation was identical to Classical Syriac Elahi.**

22. Conclusion

The word **Elahi** — ܐܠܗܝ is linguistically straightforward but historically significant.

Its basic meaning is:

“My God.”

Its morphology is:

ܐܠܗܝ → ܐ + ܐܠܗܝ

God + my → my God

The word belongs to the Aramaic/Syriac **’-L-H** lexical family and corresponds closely in meaning to Hebrew **’Eli** and **’Elohai**. Syriac grammatical and lexical evidence directly confirms its meaning, while the Peshitta employs the form in both **Mark 15:34** and **Psalm 22**.

The most important scholarly conclusion, however, is one of precision:

“Elahi” is unquestionably a Syriac/Aramaic way of saying “my God,” but the existence of this form in the Peshitta should not be confused with proof that Jesus' precise first-century Galilean pronunciation was exactly “Elahi.”

The Gospel evidence preserves **Eli** and **Eloi**, while the Syriac tradition gives **Elahi**. These forms belong to the same broad Semitic linguistic world and converge in the central meaning:

“My God.”

This linguistic observation becomes particularly important when Mark's crucifixion narrative is read against **Psalm 22**, whose Hebrew opening is itself:

אֱלֹהִי אֱלֹהִי — 'Eli 'Eli — **“My God, my God.”**

Thus, the word **Elahi** provides a valuable bridge between the **Aramaic/Syriac linguistic tradition**, the **Hebrew Psalter**, and the **Gospel tradition concerning Jesus' final cry**.

Selected Bibliography and Research Resources

1. **Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon (CAL)** — entries for 'El and 'lh/'lh'. The CAL is particularly valuable because it covers multiple Aramaic dialects and textual traditions.
2. **Kiraz, George A. — Syriac Primer / Syriac lexical resources.** The Syriac glossary explicitly gives ܐܠܗܐ = **God** and ܐܠܗܝ = **my God**.
3. **Nöldeke, Theodor. *Compendious Syriac Grammar*.** A foundational reference grammar for Classical Syriac; Syriac.ac identifies it as a standard European-language Syriac grammar.
4. **Peshitta Mark 15:34**, with morphological analysis. The text gives ܐܠܗܐ ܐܠܗܐ and identifies the morphology as first-person singular possessive.
5. **Peshitta Psalm 22**, compared with the Hebrew text. The Syriac begins with ܐܠܗܐ ܐܠܗܐ, corresponding to the Hebrew אֱלֹהִי אֱלֹהִי.
6. **Syriac grammatical resources**, including the bibliographic collection maintained by Syriac.ac.

“The Syriac/Aramaic form ܐܠܗܐ (*Elāhī*) is morphologically composed of the divine noun ܐܠܗܐ (*Elāhā*) and a first-person singular possessive element, yielding the unambiguous

meaning ‘my God’; its occurrence in the Syriac Peshitta of Mark 15:34 and Psalm 22 demonstrates a significant lexical and textual correspondence with the Gospel tradition and the Hebrew Psalm, while the distinction between Syriac *Elāhī*, Hebrew *’Eli*, and Markan Greek *Eloi* cautions against treating the later Syriac form as a direct phonetic transcription of Jesus’ first-century Galilean speech.”

Research Paper: Eloi and Eli

A Philological Word Study of Jesus’ Cry in Mark 15:34 and Matthew 27:46

Author: Pawan Upadhyay

Affiliation: Independent Researcher and Independent Scientist

Email: pawanupadhyay28@hotmail.com

2nd Email: pawankanyakubj@gmail.com

ORCID iD: <https://orcid.org/0009-0007-9077-5924>

Abstract

The expressions “**Eloi**” and “**Eli**” occupy a central position in the linguistic and textual study of Jesus’ cry from the cross. Mark 15:34 records the words in Greek transliteration as Ἐλωϊ, Ἐλωϊ (**Eloi, Eloi**), while Matthew 27:46 records Ἠλί, Ἠλί (**Eli, Eli**). Both expressions are translated, “My God, my God,” but they represent different linguistic forms and raise important questions concerning the relationship between Aramaic, Hebrew, Greek transliteration, and the Syriac textual tradition.

The evidence indicates that **Eli** corresponds closely to the Hebrew אֱלִי (’*ēlī*), “my God,” as found in Psalm 22:1. **Eloi**, meanwhile, is conventionally understood as an Aramaic form meaning “my God.” The Syriac Peshitta preserves a related form, ܐܠܗܝ (’*alāhī* / *Elāhī*), “my God.” These forms belong to the broader Northwest Semitic linguistic environment but should not be treated as identical words.

The distinction is particularly important for historical reconstruction. Jesus most probably spoke a form of **Galilean Aramaic** in ordinary life, but the surviving Gospel texts transmit his cry through Greek literary forms, while the Peshitta represents it within a later Syriac tradition. Consequently, **Eloi, Eli, and Elahi provide complementary linguistic evidence, but they do not permit absolute certainty concerning the exact phonetic form Jesus originally uttered.**

1. Introduction

The final cry attributed to Jesus in the Gospel passion narratives is one of the most linguistically significant passages in the New Testament.

Mark records:

Ἐλωϊ, Ἐλωϊ, λεμὰ σαβαχθανί
Eloi, Eloi, lema sabachthani

Matthew records:

Ἠλί, Ἠλί, λεμὰ σαβαχθανί
Eli, Eli, lema sabachthani

Both are translated:

“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”

The apparent difference between **Eloi** and **Eli** has generated considerable discussion because Jesus lived in a multilingual Jewish environment in which **Aramaic, Hebrew, and Greek** were all present.

The central research question is:

What are the linguistic identities of Eloi and Eli, and what can these forms tell us about the original language of Jesus' cry?

To answer this question, it is necessary to distinguish the following:

- Hebrew אֱלֹהִים — **’Eli**
- Hebrew אֱלֹהִים — **’Elohai**
- Greek Ἠλί — **Eli**
- Greek Ἐλωϊ — **Eloi**
- Syriac ܐܠܗܝ — **Elāhi**

2. The Historical Linguistic Environment

Jesus lived in first-century Roman Palestine, a multilingual environment.

For historical purposes, the most important languages include:

Aramaic

Aramaic was a major spoken language in Galilee and Judea and is generally regarded as the principal language of Jesus' ordinary speech.

Hebrew

Hebrew remained deeply important in Jewish religious and scriptural life. The Hebrew Scriptures were central to synagogue worship and Jewish theological discourse.

Greek

Greek functioned extensively throughout the eastern Roman world and was particularly important for administration, commerce, and interregional communication.

Therefore, describing Jesus simply as “an Aramaic speaker” is reasonable, but it does not imply that he had no interaction with Hebrew or Greek.

3. The Hebrew Form: אֱלִי (’*Eli*)

The Hebrew expression at the beginning of Psalm 22 is:

אֱלִי אֱלִי

’Eli ’Eli

Meaning:

“My God, my God.”

The underlying noun is:

אֱל — ’El

meaning:

God / god / deity

The final םִי (-î) is the first-person singular possessive suffix.

Thus:

אֱלִי → אֱלִי + םִי

God + my → my God

This is straightforward Hebrew morphology.

Psalms 22:1 therefore begins:

אֱלֹהֵי אֱלִי לָמָּה עֲזַבְתָּנִי

ʾEli ʾEli lamah ʾazavtani

“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”

This Hebrew form is critical for understanding Matthew's version.

4. Matthew 27:46 — “Eli, Eli”

Matthew preserves Jesus' cry as:

Ἑλὶ, Ἑλὶ

Transliterated:

Eli, Eli

The form closely corresponds to the Hebrew:

אֱלִי אֱלִי

of Psalm 22:1.

Matthew therefore creates an especially obvious verbal connection between Jesus' cry and the Hebrew Psalm.

The Gospel immediately provides the translation:

“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”

This is important evidence because the Gospel writer is not merely giving an isolated word. The entire expression is presented as an intentional quotation or allusion to Psalm 22.

5. Mark 15:34 — “Eloi, Eloi”

Mark uses a different form:

Ἐλωϊ, Ἐλωϊ

Eloi, Eloi

The form is conventionally understood as representing an **Aramaic** expression.

The difference between:

Eli

and:

Eloi

is therefore significant.

Mark's form appears less directly identical to the Hebrew **’Eli**, while Matthew's form closely resembles the Hebrew wording.

This may reflect differences in:

- underlying source tradition,
- dialect,
- transliteration,
- literary presentation,
- or the way each Gospel preserves the saying.

The evidence should therefore not be reduced to the assumption that one Gospel is simply “correct” and the other “incorrect.”

6. Morphological Comparison

The basic forms can be summarized:

Language	Form	Meaning
Hebrew	אל (’Ei)	God

Hebrew	אֱלִי (<i>ʿEli</i>)	My God
Hebrew	אֱלֹהַי (<i>ʿElohai</i>)	My God
Aramaic/Syriac	ܐܠܗܐ (<i>Elaha</i>)	God
Syriac	ܐܠܗܝܐ (<i>Elahi</i>)	My God
Greek transliteration	Ἑλὶ (<i>Eli</i>)	My God
Greek transliteration	Ἑλωϊ (<i>Eloi</i>)	My God

The semantic convergence is clear:

Eli = My God

Eloi = My God

Elahi = My God

But the forms are not morphologically identical.

7. Eli and Elahi Are Not the Same Word

This distinction is essential.

Hebrew

אֱלִי — *ʿEli*

is built upon:

אֱל — *ʿEl*

“God”

plus:

אִי — *-î*

“my.”

Syriac

ܐܠܗܝ — **Elāhī**

is built upon the Syriac noun:

ܐܠܗܐ — **Elāhā**

“God”

with the first-person possessive element:

ܐ — **-ī**

“my.”

Consequently:

Eli and Elahi have the same basic meaning but are not the same morphological form.

This distinction prevents a common mistake in discussions of the subject.

8. Eli and Elohai

Hebrew contains more than one way of expressing “my God.”

Two important examples are:

אֱלִי — **’Eli**

and:

אֱלֹהַי — **’Elohai**

Both mean:

“My God.”

But they derive from different nominal forms.

Eli

’Ei + ī

= My God

Elohai

Eloah/Elohim-related form + possessive morphology

= My God

Thus, the presence of **Eloi** in Mark should not automatically be explained as merely the Greek spelling of Hebrew **Elohai**.

The forms require separate analysis.

9. The Aramaic Background of Eloi

Mark's:

Ἐλωϊ — Eloi

is generally understood as an attempt to represent an Aramaic expression using Greek letters.

The transliteration process itself creates difficulties.

Greek did not possess an exact one-to-one correspondence with every Aramaic sound.

Consequently, when an Aramaic expression was written in Greek characters, its precise original pronunciation cannot always be recovered with certainty.

This is an important methodological principle:

A Greek transliteration is evidence for a spoken Semitic form, but it is not necessarily a perfect phonetic transcription.

Therefore, **Eloi** should be treated as evidence for an Aramaic form while recognizing the limitations imposed by Greek orthography.

10. The Peshitta Form: ܐܠܗܐ

The Syriac Peshitta provides another important witness:

ܐܠܗܐ

Elāhī / Alāhī

meaning:

“My God.”

The underlying Syriac noun is:

ܐܠܗܐ — **Elāhā**

“God.”

With the possessive element:

ܐܠܗܐ — **-ī**

the form becomes:

ܐܠܗܐ — **Elāhī**

“My God.”

The Syriac tradition therefore preserves a form that is linguistically close to the Aramaic language family associated with Jesus.

However, the Peshitta should not be treated as a direct recording of first-century Galilean speech. It is a Syriac textual tradition transmitted in a later linguistic environment.

11. Eloī and Elahi

The relationship can therefore be represented approximately:

Mark:

Eloī

↓

Aramaic linguistic background

↓

Syriac: Elahi

↓

Both mean:

“My God.”

However, this does not mean:

Eloi = Elahi letter for letter.

Rather:

Eloi and Elahi are related Aramaic/Syriac expressions conveying the same meaning.

Their different forms can arise from dialectal differences, morphological differences, and the transmission of Semitic speech through different writing systems.

12. The Crucial Evidence of Psalm 22

Psalm 22 is perhaps the most important textual background.

Hebrew:

אֱלֹהֵי אֱלֹהֵי

’Eli ’Eli

Greek New Testament:

’Ηλί, ’Ηλί in Matthew

and:

’Ελωϊ, ’Ελωϊ in Mark.

Syriac Peshitta:

ܐܠܗܝܐ ܐܠܗܝܐ

Elahi Elahi

All three traditions communicate:

“My God, my God.”

This makes Psalm 22 essential for interpreting the Gospel saying.

13. Matthew's Form and Psalm 22

Matthew's use of:

Eli, Eli

is particularly significant because it corresponds closely to:

Eli, Eli

in the Hebrew Psalm.

This strongly emphasizes the scriptural connection.

Matthew's Gospel repeatedly presents Jesus' passion through the framework of Israel's Scriptures.

Therefore, the similarity between:

Psalm 22:1 — Eli Eli

and:

Matthew 27:46 — Eli Eli

should be regarded as highly significant.

14. Mark's Form and Aramaic

Mark's:

Eloi Eloi

provides a somewhat different linguistic presentation.

Mark appears to preserve an Aramaic form rather than simply reproducing the Hebrew wording of Psalm 22.

This is particularly valuable because it supports the broader historical observation that Jesus' cry was transmitted as a **Semitic-language saying** within a Greek Gospel.

Mark then translates the saying for the reader:

“My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”

Thus the text itself signals that the original expression was not immediately understandable to every Greek-speaking reader.

15. Why Did Bystanders Think Jesus Was Calling Elijah?

Mark and Matthew both report that some bystanders misunderstood the cry and thought Jesus might be calling **Elijah**.

This detail is important for the linguistic discussion.

The similarity between:

Eli / Eloī

and:

Elijah

could create an auditory association for listeners unfamiliar with the saying.

This does not prove the exact pronunciation Jesus used, but it demonstrates that the Gospel tradition understood the utterance as a Semitic expression that could be misunderstood phonetically.

The narrative therefore provides indirect evidence that the saying's pronunciation mattered to the original hearers.

16. The Meaning of “My God”

Both **Eli** and **Eloī** contain the semantic concept:

“my God.”

The possessive relationship is essential.

The phrase does not merely identify God.

It addresses God personally.

Compare:

God

versus:

My God

The latter contains a first-person relationship between speaker and deity.

This is grammatically encoded in the Semitic forms.

17. Does “Eloi” Mean “My God”?

Yes.

The Greek Gospel explicitly translates the expression as:

“My God, my God...”

The Greek transliteration **Eloi** is therefore not being presented as a mysterious name or an independent deity.

It represents a Semitic expression whose meaning is:

“My God.”

The context, translation, and relationship to Psalm 22 all support this interpretation.

18. Did Jesus Say “Eli” or “Eloi”?

This question requires caution.

The surviving evidence gives us:

Matthew → Eli

Mark → Eloi

It is therefore historically unsafe to claim that we possess a verbatim recording of Jesus' precise pronunciation.

Several possibilities exist:

1. Jesus spoke a Galilean Aramaic form.
2. Different Gospel traditions preserved slightly different forms.
3. The Gospel writers adapted the form for literary or scriptural purposes.
4. Greek transliteration affected the spelling.
5. The forms reflect genuine dialectal or linguistic variation.

The evidence allows strong conclusions about **meaning**, but more limited conclusions about **exact pronunciation**.

19. Was Jesus Speaking Hebrew?

The presence of **Eli** in Matthew does not necessarily mean Jesus was speaking Hebrew at that moment.

This is because **Eli** can also occur as an Aramaic-related form and because the Gospel texts have undergone linguistic transmission.

Furthermore, Matthew's form closely resembles the Hebrew Psalm, which may reflect deliberate scriptural alignment.

Therefore:

Matthew's "Eli" should not by itself be used as proof that Jesus was speaking Hebrew rather than Aramaic.

The historical linguistic context favors an important role for Aramaic in Jesus' ordinary speech.

20. Was Jesus Speaking Syriac?

The safest historical formulation is:

Jesus spoke a Galilean form of Aramaic.

Syriac is a closely related Aramaic language/tradition but should not simply be equated with the first-century Galilean dialect.

The Syriac Peshitta therefore gives valuable comparative evidence, but:

Peshitta Syriac ≠ automatically Jesus' exact Galilean pronunciation.

This distinction is essential for academically responsible research.

21. A Four-Form Comparison

Form	Language/Tradition	Basic Meaning	Significance
'Eli	Hebrew	My God	Psalm 22
Eli	Greek transliteration	My God	Matthew 27:46
Eloi	Greek transliteration of Aramaic	My God	Mark 15:34
Elahi	Syriac	My God	Peshitta

The forms should therefore be understood as **related witnesses**, not as four identical spellings.

22. Philological Reconstruction

A cautious reconstruction can be represented:

Hebrew Psalm

'Eli 'Eli

↓

“My God, my God”

Aramaic Gospel tradition

Eloi Eloi

↓

“My God, my God”

Syriac Christian tradition

Elāhi Elāhi

↓

“My God, my God”

The semantic continuity is exceptionally strong.

The exact phonetic history is less certain.

23. The Importance of the Greek Text

The New Testament was written in Greek, and therefore the Greek text is our primary manuscript evidence for Matthew and Mark.

This means:

Eli and Eloi

are preserved for us in Greek letters.

We should therefore distinguish:

what the Greek manuscripts actually say

from:

what we reconstruct as the underlying Aramaic pronunciation.

This distinction is fundamental to historical philology.

24. Why Transliteration Matters

When a word passes from one alphabet into another, information can be lost.

For example:

Aramaic → Greek

does not provide an exact equivalent for every Aramaic consonant and vowel.

Therefore, the form:

Eloi

should not be analyzed as though it were originally written using the Aramaic alphabet.

It is a **Greek representation of a Semitic expression**.

This is why comparison with Aramaic and Syriac evidence is useful.

25. Relationship to “Elahi”

The word study of **Elahi** and the present study of **Eloi/Eli** should complement one another.

Elahi

ܐܠܗܝ

= My God

Eloi

Ἐλωϊ

= My God

Eli

ܐܠܝ / Ἠλί

= My God

The three forms therefore converge semantically:

ELI — ELOI — ELAHI = “MY GOD.”

But their linguistic forms and textual histories remain distinct.

26. Theological Implications

The linguistic evidence itself should not be forced to answer theological questions that belong to systematic theology.

Philologically, the phrase says:

“My God.”

The speaker addresses God directly.

Theologically, different Christian traditions have interpreted the cry in relation to:

- Jesus' suffering,
- Psalm 22,
- the incarnation,
- the relationship between the Son and the Father,
- substitutionary suffering,
- abandonment,
- and the fulfillment of Scripture.

Those theological interpretations should be distinguished from the linguistic meaning of **Eli/Eloi**.

The philological conclusion remains straightforward:

Eli/Eloi means “My God.”

27. Main Conclusions

The evidence supports the following conclusions.

1. “Eli” means “My God”

The Hebrew form:

אֱלִי — 'Eli

is morphologically “my God.”

2. Matthew's “Eli” closely resembles Psalm 22

Matthew 27:46 uses:

Eli, Eli

which closely corresponds to Psalm 22:1.

3. “Eloi” is an Aramaic-related form

Mark 15:34 preserves:

Eloi, Eloi

and presents it as the cry of Jesus.

4. “Elahi” is a Syriac/Aramaic form

The Syriac:

ܐܠܗܝ — Elāhī

means:

“My God.”

5. The forms are related but not identical

Eli, Eloi, and Elahi should not be treated as merely different spellings of one identical word.

They represent different linguistic forms within closely related Semitic traditions.

6. Exact pronunciation cannot be established with absolute certainty

The Gospel manuscripts preserve Greek transliterations of Semitic speech.

Therefore, we can establish the **meaning** with much greater confidence than the exact phonetic pronunciation.

28. Final Conclusion

The expressions **Eli** and **Eloi** provide important linguistic evidence concerning Jesus' cry from the cross.

Eli corresponds closely to Hebrew:

אֱלִי — 'Eli

“My God.”

Eloi, preserved in Mark, represents an Aramaic expression meaning:

“**My God.**”

The Syriac Peshitta provides the related form:

ܐܠܗܝ — Elāhī

“My God.”

Consequently, the three forms can be understood as follows:

Hebrew: 'Eli

Aramaic: Eloi

Syriac: Elāhī

Meaning: “My God”

The strongest historical conclusion is therefore not that Jesus necessarily pronounced one particular later Syriac form, but that **the Gospel tradition preserves a Semitic cry meaning “My God, my God,” rooted explicitly in Psalm 22.**

Matthew's **Eli** highlights the Hebrew wording of Psalm 22, while Mark's **Eloi** preserves an Aramaic form. The later Syriac **Elahi** demonstrates how the same basic expression is represented within Syriac Aramaic.

Thus, the linguistic evidence presents a remarkable continuity:

Psalm 22: “Eli, Eli”

↓

Jesus tradition: “Eli / Eloi, Eloi”

↓

Syriac tradition: “Elahi, Elahi”

↓

Meaning: “My God, my God.”

The evidence therefore supports a nuanced conclusion: **Jesus' cry belongs to the Aramaic-speaking world of first-century Galilee, while the Gospel forms Eli and Eloi and the Syriac Elahi preserve closely related linguistic expressions whose semantic center is the personal address, "My God."**

Selected Bibliography

Primary Texts

- Psalm 22:1 — Hebrew Masoretic Text
- Matthew 27:46 — Greek New Testament
- Mark 15:34 — Greek New Testament
- Peshitta Psalm 22
- Peshitta Mark 15:34

Linguistic Resources

- Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon (CAL), Hebrew Union College.
- Kiraz, George A. *The New Syriac Primer*.
- Nöldeke, Theodor. *Compendious Syriac Grammar*.
- Payne Smith, Robert. *A Compendious Syriac Dictionary*.
- Sokoloff, Michael. *A Syriac Lexicon*.